

College Bound

ISSUES & TRENDS FOR THE COLLEGE ADMISSIONS ADVISOR

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EDITOR'S NOTE: This issue marks the end of the **40th year** of *COLLEGE BOUND: Issues and Trends for the College Admissions Advisor*. It has been an honor to serve you—high school counselors, parents, college admissions advisors, students and the general public. It has always been our mission to supply accurate information and the latest news on trends, data and resources for college-bound students and their parents and schools. All the new technology in the world will not change that. You can rely on us. Have a great Summer! ■

Admissions Watch Late Spring Tallies

APPLICATIONS to colleges were up 2 percent in 2026. "The 2026 U.S. college admissions cycle saw an average of 6.59 applications per student, a 5 percent increase in total submissions against a 2 percent rise in unique applicants," according to an AI-generated article on MSN.

"Colleges are also adopting AI to speed essay review, though most have yet to formalize rules for applicant AI use," MSN reported. "The surge is making it harder for institutions to predict enrollment and intensifying competition for places."

Arizona's Yield Up. The yield for the incoming Class of 2030 at the U. of Arizona is higher than the last few years, Patricia Prelock, provost, told AU's Faculty Senate, according to tucson.com. Also, the new students' average high school GPA, 3.65, is higher than last year's 3.43. Enrollment at UA's Honors C. is at an all-time high as well. However, international enrollment is down, as it is nationally after the Trump administration's crackdown on international student visas and immigration.

Brandeis Apps Up 40 Percent. Applications to Brandeis U. in Massachusetts soared by 40 percent this year, according to *The Justice*. However, fall enrollment is expected to be about the same as the last academic year.

"This class is one of the best we've ever admitted," Arthur Levine, president, told the faculty during its spring meeting. "But it's not as big as it could be," he said. "We managed to expand the top of the funnel. The task next

year is to take the bottom of the funnel and translate it into acceptances."

Florida State Attracts Non-Residents, Despite Tuition Increase. *The Tallahassee Democrat* reported that "despite an upcoming 15 percent boost in tuition for students from outside of Florida enrolling into the state's public institutions which kicks in this fall, more applications to Florida State and Florida A&M universities rolled in from out-of-staters looking to enroll this year, as compared to last year."

FSU received 45,709 applications from out-of-state and international students this year, over 6,000 more than last year. Total apps reached 96,415 applications for both Florida residents and out-of-state students. Tuition has not increased in more than a decade.

Hobart and William Smith's Enrollment Surges. Hobart and William Smith, located in Geneva, New York, on the north end of Seneca Lake, recruited 568 first-year students for this fall, 20 percent more than last year, pushing total campus enrollment above 2,000 students for the first time in years, according to FingerLakes.com. According to HWS, student inquiries climbed nearly 30 percent year-over-year to 18,989, while applications rose 15.7 percent to 6,699.

New students hail from 35 states and multiple countries, including Bangladesh, Poland, the United Kingdom and El Salvador. College officials reported that the class enters with

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Financial Matters

FAFSA Record. The Class of 2026 set a FAFSA completion record, according to the National College Attainment Network. Some 54.7 percent of seniors nationwide completed their forms by May 1, making them eligible for Pell Grants, as well as most federal, state and institutional financial aid.

NCAN noted, "The Class of 2026 represents a remarkable, encouraging turnaround. Two years ago, during the difficult rollout of the Better FAFSA, the high school Class of 2024 reached just 46 percent completion by June 30. The Class of 2025 greatly improved on that by reaching 53.9 percent by the end of June. The Class of 2026, in turn, has completed nearly 12 percent more FAFSAs through May 1 than the Class of 2025 had by the same date."

NCAN cited a few reasons for the good participation. "The 2026-27 FAFSA cycle opened not only on time but early on September 24... the FAFSA process for most families is speedier, smoother and simpler this year. The Office of Federal Student Aid deserves a lot of credit for not only the fixes in the process but also the improvements it has made. Changes like instant verification during the StudentAid.gov account creation process for most users with a Social Security number is a game changer.

"Instant verification means students and families aren't waiting multiple days to get started with the FAFSA process, and it means that college advisors running financial aid nights can help students complete the process all at once, rather than over multiple days.

"Beyond that, FSA also reduced the number of fields and screens needed to set up the ID and eliminated the challenge questions and have con-

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SPRING TALLIES

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an average GPA of 3.64. Some 62 percent graduated from public high schools. Roughly 36 percent of incoming students are expected to compete in varsity athletics across HWS's 31 sports programs.

"Hobart and William Smith continues to distinguish itself through the strength of our academic program, the power of experiential learning and the outcomes students and families seek," explained President Mark Gearan.

New Haven's Record. The U. of New Haven in Connecticut received more than 22,000 applications for its Class of 2030 and by May 1, received 1,400 deposits for seats this fall.

"Our Charger community is grateful for the confidence and trust our students and families have in our mission and vision," said Jessica Goddu, executive director of undergraduate admissions. "Ultimately, our large incoming class is testament to the immersive and engaging learning opportunities created by our talented faculty in and out of the classroom and the devot-

ed individuals across our University community who tirelessly support our students' success."

NACAC's Last-Minute Openings. For its 39th year, the National Association for College Admission Counseling has posted a list of colleges and universities that are still accepting applications for the Fall 2026 semester, schools from Alma C. in Michigan to Wichita State U. in Kansas. Find it at College Openings Update National Association for College Admission Counseling, <http://www.nacacnet.org>. ■

TUITION TABS

U. of Chicago Tuition Free for Under \$250,000. Beginning Fall 2027, U. of Chicago students from families earning less than \$250,000 a year will attend tuition free. Students from families making less than \$125,000 also will receive free housing, meals and other benefits.

U. of C. tuition currently stands at around \$71,000 a year. Add room, board, books and other fees, it costs full-pay students about \$98,000 a year.

"The University of Chicago is proud to sponsor a learning environment characterized by intellectual curiosity, ambition and rigor, to shape the next generation of great thinkers whose ideas will benefit the American people and the broader world," President Paul Alivisatos said. "By deepening our commitment to affordability, we are helping to ensure that the brightest minds can join us."

Macalester's Tuition Promise. Macalester C. in St. Paul, Minnesota, is launching the Macalester Tuition Promise in Fall 2026, guaranteeing a full-tuition scholarship to all undergraduate students with a family income below \$100,000.

"I think Macalester felt this was important because the process of applying to college and applying for need-based financial aid is very complex and complicated," Jeff Allen, vice president of Admissions and Financial Aid, said. "We feel it may be a barrier that prevents very talented kids from applying in the first place."

Allen said 51 incoming freshmen are receiving the Macalester Promise out of a class of 560. Macalester's tuition with room and board is about \$92,000 a year.

Swarthmore's Tuition Guarantee. Swarthmore C., which already meets 100 percent of every student's determined financial need with loan-free financial aid packages and "ensures that all students have the opportunity to fully immerse themselves in Swarthmore's residential liberal arts experience with train rides to Philadelphia, to our Textbook Affordability

Program, to countless concerts, performances, lectures, athletic events, and even laundry, all at no extra cost to students and families, announced its new Swarthmore Tuition Guarantee."

Starting in Fall 2027, Swarthmore will cover at least the full cost of tuition for students whose families earn \$200,000 or less with typical assets.

President Val Smith wrote, "We hope the Tuition Guarantee helps communicate that a Swarthmore education is affordable for families from across the economic spectrum. In fact, Swarthmore regularly provides financial aid to families earning well above \$200,000 a year, based on their individual circumstances."

"The Swarthmore Tuition Guarantee is more than a financial aid program; it's a powerful demonstration of our belief that a student's intellectual curiosity, creativity and talent should decide what's possible, not whether they can pay for tuition."

Texas Tuition Increase on Hold. Texas Governor Greg Abbott paused all increases to collegiate undergraduate tuition for the 2026-2027 school year, according to KVUE. The pause applies to four-year and two-year institutions.

Tuition and fees have been frozen in the state since 2023, when Texas invested more than \$680 million "to reform community college funding and expand degree pathways for students." In 2025, Texas funded \$328 million more for financial aid programs across the state.

"Higher education must be attainable for Texas students and families," Abbott wrote in a letter to college and university presidents. "Access to affordable, high-quality higher education is essential to ensure Texans learn the skills needed to secure family-sustaining jobs and meet the demands of a growing workforce.... Texas must continue leading the nation in creating affordable pathways to higher education while maintaining the high academic standards that make our institutions strong," the governor's letter stated. ■

FINANCIAL MATTERS

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tinued mid-cycle to look at process performance to try to eliminate places that trip up users....

"Nine states now have universal FAFSA policies, which set some kind of requirement on students or schools to complete the FAFSA or opt out of doing so.... including many large states like California, Texas, Illinois, New York and New Jersey. These policies put upward pressure on the nationwide FAFSA completion rate....

"Six states—Tennessee, Illinois, Texas, New Jersey, California, and New York—have already achieved FAFSA completion rates of 60 percent or greater through May 1, and these will undoubtedly increase." See, www.ncan.org.

Aid for the "Missing Middle." According to a recent report from the Brookings Institution, "middle-income families, typically earning \$50,000–\$125,000, fall into a 'missing middle' where they earn too much for meaningful need-based aid but too little to comfortably afford college. The affordability crisis facing middle-income students is not simply a funding shortfall: it is a design failure in how aid formulas assess and respond to financial need.

"New initiatives show how shared investment across sectors, more predictable aid structures and intentional reductions in unmet need can relieve the burden on the missing middle."

Price Transparency Imperative. A new report from Strata Education Foundation, based in Indianapolis, "shows that a large part of the uneasiness students and families feel stems from an inability to determine whether post-secondary education is actually affordable. And while providing more clarity and greater transparency will help address some of the confusion, rebuilding trust may also require significant structural reforms around price modeling, financial aid packaging and communications.

"Based on research with more than 5,000 students, parents, adult learners and members of the public, this report explores both the current climate and the potential for new approaches to pricing and transparency about the cost of college." See, *The Price Transparency Imperative: Rebuilding Confidence in Higher Education* | Strata Education Foundation. ■

Enrollment Trends

International Graduate Enrollment Growth Appears to End.

"International graduate enrollment surpassed half a million students in 2024, but the era of sustained growth has clearly ended. That's according to Chris Gardiner, Eduventures Senior Analyst at Encoura, in May.

"Preliminary Fall 2025 data showed a staggering 17 percent drop in new enrollments, reinforcing broader concerns already reshaping institutional enrollment strategy,"

Why? "Heavy dependence on India and China, which together account for three out of five international graduate students in the U.S., has heightened international exposure as both pipelines soften."

The problem? "According to Open Doors 2024-25, 96 percent of institutions cited visa delays and denials as the primary driver of enrollment drops, while 67 percent reported that students increasingly feel unwelcomed in the U.S. Rising tuition, living costs and geopolitical tensions are compounding those concerns. The impact is particularly acute in STEM fields, where international students make up a substantial share of graduate enrollment."

What's next? "Institutions that rely heavily on students from India and China will remain under pressure, as both markets are expected to continue contracting over the next several years. Institutions cannot afford to wait for another policy reversal or assume the market will simply reverse course. This is a pivot point: international graduate enrollment remains sizable, but it is no longer a default growth strategy."

Minority Majority. "Non-white students now make up the largest share of American universities' enrollment, though the diversity on campuses varies," according to the *Chronicle of Higher Education's* recent review of Fall 2024 data.

Central Michigan's Challenge. CMU, founded in 1892 in Mount Pleasant, has experienced "a constant enrollment decline throughout the past 10 years, dropping from 24,445 students in Fall 2016 to 13,244

in spring 2026, which is an over 45 percent decrease, according to the university's enrollment data," reported *Central Michigan Life*, the student newspaper. CMU, with an acceptance rate of 90 percent, touts academic strengths in business, education, health professions and communication and media.

New Hampshire Attracts Nurses. In May, the Community College System of New Hampshire graduated 347 nursing students, the most in more than 10 years, according to the *New Hampshire Business Review*.

"Nurses are the cornerstone of our health care system, and we are fortunate to have exceptional nurse educators across our seven colleges who provide New Hampshire with the nation's best prepared nurses..." said CCSNH Chancellor Mark Rubinstein.

Meanwhile, the U. of New Hampshire put an early end to the undergraduate enrollment into its newly-established School of Nursing because of overwhelming interest in the flagship university's programs.

"We are thrilled at the strong interest in UNH's nursing programs," Kirsten Corazzini, dean of the UNH College of Health and Human Services, told the *Review*. "These are not only wonderful, rewarding career paths for students, but they will also help the Granite State address its growing health care workforce needs."

Vermont Hit by Demographic Cliff. The U. of Vermont just graduated 2,600 students. But UVM President Marlene Tromp told her Board of Trustees that she anticipates an enrollment decline for Fall 2026, according to UVM News. She cited multiple contributing factors such as changing perceptions of the value of higher education, increased competition from other top institutions and arrival of the long-anticipated demographic cliff.

Vice President for Enrollment Management Jay Jacobs added that this is a national admissions trend and outlined numerous steps UVM is taking to bolster its admissions process and create clearer pathways. ■

SCHOLARSHIP SCOOPS

Alfred U.'s PTK Scholarship. Alfred U. in Western New York announced a new partnership with the Phi Theta Kappa Honor Society, an international honor society for students enrolled in two-year colleges with 1,300 chapters worldwide. PTK members can qualify for direct admission to Alfred U. with the potential for \$28,000 in annual scholarships.

"PTK Direct Admissions allows us to recognize high-achieving transfer students, simplify the transfer process and most importantly allows us to help students realize their purpose here at Alfred University," said Kyla Whannell, director of admissions.

Lynchburg Support. The U. of Lynchburg in Virginia announced a new \$25,000 scholarship for first-generation college students from "Southside Virginia." See, Philanthropic alumni couple memorialized with new scholarship | University of Lynchburg.

Mississippi Aid. In April, Mississippi Governor Tate Reeves signed a law establishing the UPSKILL (Upgrading Priority Skills for Key Industry Learning and Labor) Mississippi Grant program for students seeking an associate's degree. See, UPSKILL would offset some college costs, reported in *Mississippi Today*.

Competition for Excelsior Scholarship Opens. Application for the New York State Excelsior Scholarship is now open for new applicants for the 2026-27 academic year. It provides eligible full-time students with tuition-free attendance to the SUNY or CUNY two-year or four-year colleges.

Students choosing to attend a participating private college in New York State can receive up to \$6,000 toward their tuition costs through the Enhanced Tuition Award.

"Higher education should be a pathway to opportunity, not a source of financial strain,"

said New York Governor Kathy Hochul. "Programs like the Excelsior Scholarship and the Enhanced Tuition Award put opportunity within reach for thousands of New Yorkers ready to take the next step toward a college degree."

The Excelsior Scholarship is administered by the New York State Higher Education Services Corporation. Deadline is August 31.

Connecticut College's Langer Scholars.

Connecticut C. in New London recently graduated 16 Langer Scholars, all of whom posted GPAs in the top three percent of the graduating class. According to *The College Voice*, Langer Scholars date back to 1928. "This year was the second year the students were named Langer Scholars instead of Winthrop Scholars, formerly named in honor of New London's city founder and Connecticut governor John Winthrop the Younger. The award was renamed to recognize Susanne K. Langer, one of the first nationally recognized women philosophers and a professor emerita of the College." ■

CURRICULUM CAPSULES

Brandeis U.'s "Micro-credentials." Brandeis U. is in the second round of its micro-credentials program. According to *The Justice*, eight new micro-credential submissions are under review: Civil Discourse and Conflict Resolution; Cultural Competence; Instrumentation; Design in Three Dimensions: Art, Engineering and Imagination; Natural Language Processing; Collaborative Communication and Business; Intermediate Language Competency; Sports Communications and Media Innovation.

Sports Communications and Media Innovation is the first co-curricular micro-credential, shared by the Journalism and Athletics departments. The other micro-credentials span departments ranging from Legal Studies and Theater to Engineering and Computer Science.

These micro-credentials are a "way of recognizing skills students learn, not only in the classroom, but in their extracurricular activities and Brandeis passions." During the first round, 24 students achieved 26 micro-credentials. These are notated on their transcripts.

Harvard Caps "A" at 20 Percent. To combat grade inflation and revive academic standards,

70 percent of Harvard U.'s faculty voted in May to cap the number of "A's" awarded in any undergraduate class at 20 percent, beginning Fall 2027. According to the *Harvard Crimson*, the faculty also voted to use percentages instead of GPA's in determining awards and honors.

More than 60 percent of Harvard undergraduate grades awarded during the 2024-25 academic year were A's. Perhaps that is why nearly 85 percent of students in a February survey opposed the new plan. Many critics fear that the new policy will heighten cut-throat competition and "discourage intellectual risk-taking and infringe on faculty autonomy." Students also may avoid more difficult classes.

"This is a consequential vote," said Amanda Claybaugh, dean of undergraduate education. "It will, I believe, strengthen the academic culture of Harvard; it will also, I hope, encourage other institutions to confront similar questions with the same level of rigor and courage."

Vermont's Student Success Initiatives. Jennifer Dickinson, U. of Vermont Vice Provost for Academic Affairs and Student Success, recently updated the school's Board of Trustees on several student success initiatives.

STEM Scholars is a signature initiative aimed at attracting and developing high-achieving students poised to lead in science, technology, engineering and mathematics. As one of a select group of institutions chosen by the Howard Hughes Medical Institute to build a Success in Science program, UVM is designing an experience that blends academic rigor with real-world exposure.

She noted that participants begin with lab internships, industry visits and coursework in intercultural dialogue, helping them cultivate technical expertise alongside teamwork, self-awareness and a clear sense of purpose.

Another initiative, StudyCATS, focuses on unlocking the potential of students who may need additional academic support early in their college careers. Funded by the Davis Educational Foundation, this program helps students better understand campus resources, develop effective study and time-management strategies and build confidence in their ability to succeed at UVM.

Another student success initiative, ASK UVM, makes it easier for students to navigate campus resources and get help when they need it. This initiative serves as a welcoming first point of contact, where trained Student Guides assist peers in identifying next steps, connecting with services, scheduling appointments and overcoming barriers to access. ■

NEWS YOU CAN USE

California Profs Call for Return to Testing. "Citing 'severe' math deficits, UC faculty demand a return to SAT tests for STEM applicants," reads a May 27 *Los Angeles Times* headline. "Hundreds of UC faculty are urging a return of SAT or ACT test requirements for STEM applicants, citing math deficits after six years of being test-free."

More than 600 U. of California faculty members, led by mathematicians at UC Berkeley, called on the system to reinstate standardized testing requirements for science, technology, engineering and mathematics applicants.

Their open letter, addressed to top UC leaders, asks for SAT or ACT exams to be required beginning in Fall 2027 and for STEM faculty to be given formal oversight of readiness standards in their majors.

"We now observe preparation gaps so severe that instructors must reteach middle-school mathematics while simultaneously teaching the material students need for sciences, engineering, economics and other quantitatively demanding fields," they warned.

The *Times* noted that from Fall 2021 to Fall 2023, at least 20 percent of Berkeley first-semester calculus students who took a diagnostic exam showed deficits. "Basic

mathematical fluency is analogous to literacy; without it, success in university-level STEM becomes structurally unattainable for students," faculty wrote.

What Seniors Should Do This Summer to Prepare For College Admissions. Writing this May in *Forbes*, Christopher Rim, CEO of Command Education, urged prospective college students to do three things this summer.

He wrote, "At the beginning of the summer break, August 1st seems like a lifetime away. Rising seniors often spend June and July telling themselves that they will worry about their college application prep after their family vacation, summer internship or academic program. But predictably, every year, August creeps up faster than students expect. The Common App opens, and they find themselves staring at a blank screen with writer's block and an unfinished college list."

So, they should begin thinking about their applications now. "The students who submit the strongest applications are not necessarily the most academically proficient or credentialed, but those who start early, approach the process strategically and devote ample time for

brainstorming and editing."

They should "1. Finalize the Balanced College List; 2. Brainstorm the Personal Statement; 3. Build a Support Infrastructure Before the Fall."

Lessons for College Graduates. Also in *Forbes* in May, Marshall Shepherd, senior contributor, former NASA scientist, meteorology professor and college administrator, wrote an "Open Letter to 2026 College Graduates" offering six lessons to remember.

First of all, "Your Degree Matters." He quoted a Pew Research Center study, "After decades of falling wages, young U.S. workers (ages 25 to 34) without a bachelor's degree haven't seen their earnings increase over the past 10 years."

He also pointed to a Lumina Foundation study that found, "Nearly half of employers say most jobs at their organization require a college degree to be successful.... Three-quarters say a degree will be as important or more important five years from now.... The reality is that employers still use the degree as a sorting device. It serves as a baseline for competence, persistence and cognitive ability," the study continued. ■

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